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Contents

List of Figures viii

Preface ix

Acknowledgements xiv

Abbreviations xvii

Chronology xxv

'Things Look Black for the Persians: The "American Century" Begins!' xxvii

Prologue: MI5 in the Middle East 1

1 Ratcatchers 9

2 Security Threats and Operational Channels 39

3 Fifth Columnists 50

4 Fierce Tribes and Princely Playboys 64

5 Quislings and Ordinary Persians 80

6 Strategic Deceivers 95

7 Saboteurs and Spooks 101

8 Operation PONGO 120

9 Secondees from India 132

10 Interrogators and Custodians 142

11 Ruskies 153

12 'Operation LONG JUMP' 170

13 Yanks 195

14 Standing Down 231

Epilogue: The Need to Know 238

Appendix 255

Select Bibliography 260

Index 275

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Prologue: MI5 in the Middle East

> The importance of retaining the use of Abadan refinery cannot be overestimated. If this refinery were destroyed, we have not sufficient tanker tonnage to supply the wants of the Middle East and India, and our position in the Middle East would dry up for lack of oil. (War Cabinet Joint Planning Staff)[1]

To many it may seem curious that the Royal Air Force (Air Staff Intelligence Iraq) should have been responsible throughout the Second World War for the administration of the predominantly British and Indian army ground formation, Combined Intelligence Centre Iraq and Persia (CICI), that answered for the security of occupied Iraq and Persia, including the great Anglo-Iranian Oil Company (AIOC) refinery at Abadan and the oil infrastructure of Khuzistan. Traditionally, however, ever since the First World War, responsibility for Middle East and Central Asian intelligence had rested solely with the RAF, mainly because the vast distances involved in maintaining an intelligence presence in those remote regions could only be covered by aircraft. The strongest advocate for this system of aerial control and policing was Winston Churchill, who was compelled as Secretary of State for War and Air during the 1920s to find an operational alternative to land-based forces in Mesopotamia, mainly because of their iniquitous cost.[2] Interestingly, one of those most closely associated with the elaboration and implementation of Churchill's air-substitution policy at the Middle East Department of the Colonial Office was none other than Reader Bullard, who as British minister (and later ambassador) in Tehran figures prominently in this book.[3] Clearly, because of this high-level experience, from the very onset of his posting to the Persian legation in 1939

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Bullard must have possessed far greater regional security expertise than would normally be attributed to a diplomat, even one so senior. It may partially explain why he, as we shall see, so resolutely supported and facilitated the work of the secret services and security forces operating within his Persian bailiwick throughout the war.

And so – a full decade after British and Indian land forces had ceded overall command of Iraq to the air force[4] – RAF Habbaniya, a large strategic air and seaplane base, was constructed at enormous but relatively acceptable expense in the mid-1930s about 89 km west of Baghdad. It became the logical choice as the administrative nerve-centre for all intelligence, counterintelligence, and security operations east of Suez, once the Hashemite Kingdom had been established (in 1932), and the RAF had abandoned its operational centre at Rowanduz in Iraqi Kurdistan.[5] Lest it be thought that the RAF's mandate in the region as originally conceived by Churchill was provisional rather than permanent and merely perpetuated by expediency at the outbreak of war in 1939, the following description of Habbaniya by the well-connected, highly observant, and hugely popular British star of stage and screen Joyce Grenfell has set the record indelibly straight. In her 1944 diary, on her way to entertain the troops in Persia, Grenfell described an enormous 'impersonal' camp of incomparable luxury in the middle of the Iraqi desert near the Euphrates which had cost many millions to build in the 1930s. Grenfell believed that her aunt, Nancy Astor, had asked a lot of 'silly and awkward questions' about spending public money on it at the time. Anyway, it was spent, lavishly, and the result was very splendid and rather unreal. 'It's got everything,' Grenfell wrote, 'pools, polo, football, tennis, a huge movie house, clubs galore, a first-class hospital ... , bungalow quarters for everyone with bathrooms to every room, trees, gardens – everything. And in 1935 it was just twelve square miles of dust.'[6]

In fact, RAF Habbaniya was a very large base indeed. At its height (1941–42) it was staffed by no fewer than 7500 personnel (446 officers, 5603 other ranks [ORs], and 1571 civilians); how many of these people were involved in intelligence and security operations is unclear. Two years later, however, after the strategic turning points in the war at El Alamein and Stalingrad and the subsequent transfer of Allied land and air forces to other theatres, the base had swiftly shrunk to nothing more than a token operational presence, useful mainly as a refuelling station for RAF and BOAC long-range aircraft heading for India, the Far East, and Australasia, including flying boats, which could berth on the 140 km^2 lake.[7] Whereas in 1942 two entire Habbaniya-based Hurricane squadrons had been exclusively dedicated to flying regular sorties to

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the east over the Abadan oil refinery in southwest Persia, by June 1943 only four aircraft were left at Habbaniya to perform that and other tasks, two of which were venerable Gladiators. They were even outnumbered by the 8–10 dummy aircraft deployed on the tarmac to bamboozle the enemy into believing that Habbaniya was still an operational threat. On 19 June, the Air Officer Commanding (AOC) minuted that there was no fighter squadron left in the entire Iraq Command; that the defence of the two most vital enemy targets in the region (the Abadan and Kirkuk oil refineries) devolved entirely on the anti-aircraft artillery stationed in those places; and that there remained no air reporting system anywhere in the Command to warn of approaching enemy aircraft.[8] By this time, however, the RAF had fortunately been relieved of all but its administrative responsibility for intelligence and security operations. Its successor was Security Intelligence Middle East (SIME): the improbable anomaly of an MI5-controlled, interservice counterintelligence and security-intelligence organization, administered by the 'Brylcreem Boys', but staffed predominantly by British and Indian army personnel, whose backgrounds and training reflected an extensive legacy of expertise in colonial policing and management. Even less probable is the fact that this peculiar structural combination not only worked, but it proved from the start to be immensely successful, mainly because of the vision and rigorous consistency of its leaders.

Originally, it was Sir Archibald Wavell who, during the first month of the war, had conceived of the need for security intelligence to be organized on a Middle East basis.[9] At Wavell's insistence, Raymond Maunsell, a former tanks officer who had served with the Transjordan Frontier Force (TJFF) between 1930 and 1931,[10] and who had been based in Cairo as Defence Security Officer since 1937, was seconded to the army from MI5 in October 1939 and submitted a series of proposals for an 'MI5 of the Middle East', all of which were rejected for budgetary and administrative reasons by two successive Deputy Directors of Military Intelligence (DDMI).[11] Nevertheless, the extraordinarily efficient and successful organization called SIME was eventually developed from Maunsell's original concept owing to the persistent feeling both in London and in Cairo that, notwithstanding administrative objections, the central coordination of counterintelligence was necessary and that the problem was 'an indivisible whole' in the Middle East.[12] It was originally intended that SIME should be called Preventive Intelligence Arab World (PIAW); however, since the area to be covered included Persia, Turkey, and parts of Abyssinia, the more suitable title of Security Intelligence Middle East was adopted.

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SIME was therefore 'to coordinate information of all anti-British agents whether or not of German nationality working in [the] area covered by MEIC [Middle East Intelligence Centre]'.[13] The object was to locate them, keep track of their movements, and deal with them, 'should opportunity offer'.[14] In fact, this defensive nexus of coordinated security-intelligence measures, in concert with the deception operations run by Dudley Clarke's 'A' Force, proved so effective that the manifestly uncoordinated German, Italian, and Japanese espionage services were unable to obtain any useful information from the Middle East, despite the existence of disaffected, pro-Axis elements among the indigenous populations. According to David Mure, one of Clarke's staff officers, 'in the whole of the Middle East there literally was no genuine Axis espionage network',[15] and Guy Liddell of MI5 wrote conclusively in his diary: 'It is probably true to say that the Abwehr have failed to obtain any reliable information of strategic importance.'[16] Meanwhile, the skilful doubling, tripling, and playback by the Allied services of enemy agents also ensured that a great deal of disinformation reached the Axis spymasters. By far the most interesting source on these Middle East deception operations is David Mure, who was directly involved in them at an executive level and who wrote: 'we were able to control the German military espionage service in all areas occupied by the Western Allies and supply all their information'.[17]

The Allied view of the German intelligence services operating in the Middle East was never complimentary, yet neither was it complacent. Shortly after the Anglo-Soviet invasion of Persia, the head of SIME noted that the enemy espionage organization in the Middle East had never been efficient; that, being newcomers in the area, the Germans were in the process of making all the mistakes that the British had long forgotten; and that recent events in Persia had disorganized whatever organization existed. But he went on: 'I am not suggesting that we have any cause for complacency and we have no intentions of "sitting back," as we know that the enemy is directing every effort to reconstituting his espionage organization.'[18]

Raymond Maunsell's boldly innovative leadership of SIME was characterized both by his unique leadership style and by the operational principles he instilled in his officers, ORs, and civilians. While SIME was technically part of Middle East Forces (MEF), Maunsell simply could not see the point of applying a rigid military hierarchy and a unified code of behaviour to a heterogeneous interservice/civilian staff. He felt there was nothing to be gained by having a military-type discipline in a body consisting of regular army, RAF, and RNVR officers, and civilians with

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honorary or temporary commissions, to say nothing of the extremely efficient and hard-working 'lady civilians' – all were 'part of the show'. Maunsell encouraged the use of first names. 'I particularly strove to encourage the SIME [organization] to be a friendly and quick-working one, and I didn't give a damn how they wore their uniforms or, indeed, what they wore', he wrote.[19]

Maunsell thoroughly believed that his was the best paradigm for '"working" a mixed bag of people engaged in operations of complexity, nicely seasoned with embarrassments, successes, and occasional absurdities'.[20] Yet, when it came to operations, there was nothing lax or inefficient about SIME. Indeed, Maunsell insisted on the strict observance of certain 'general working principles' throughout the organization: careful and exact administration; unending patience, accessibility, and an 'inexpungable' sense of humour; the importance of 'dedramatization', which Maunsell defined as the stressing of the 'ordinariness' of human activities ('the necessity of trying to interpret dramatic police or other reports, e.g. the apparently suspicious behaviour of individuals may often be due to the secret pursuit of homo- or heterosexual relationships');[21] the necessity for constant, if not daily, contact with local commanders, other British intelligence organizations, and the local special police; the importance of consultation with each other; the importance of vetting; and, finally, the importance of cutting across channels. In this connection, Maunsell wrote: 'It was a principle of operation that different SIME areas (Defence Security Offices) and, indeed, individual officers in different areas, should communicate directly with each other and only refer to SIME Head Office if help was required or if it was vital for the Head of SIME to know about the matter in question at once …'.[22] So, the absence of formality in Maunsell's organization was clearly not associated with any absence of rigour or professionalism in operational procedures. Indeed, as David Mure has pointed out, in the Middle East all the security and clandestine organizations – SIME, ISLD, and 'A' Force – were service-staffed and functioned admirably in far more difficult circumstances than those obtaining in the UK. Being service organizations, they were free of 'the plague of the civilian MI5 in 1944 … indiscipline'. A man under service conditions was forced to maintain a high standard of conduct as he was liable, rightly, to be sternly disciplined for the slightest misdemeanour. 'One immediately thinks of homosexuality, then a criminal offence,' wrote Mure, 'perpetual drunkenness, drug taking, black market operations. People like Burgess [and] Blunt … would not have survived six weeks in the Middle East intelligence services.'[23] One wonders what Mure made

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of the flamboyantly camp Alex Kellar of B Branch, whom he probably encountered during the war, and who served MI5 in exemplary fashion well into the Cold War era.

Certainly, none of the Cambridge Five would have felt at home amidst the regulation and discipline of SIME's security-intelligence HQ in occupied Tehran – the Defence Security Office Persia (DSO Persia), also known as CICI Tehran or just DSO – where things under Joe Spencer's able command were managed strictly, efficiently, and anything but casually. From his arrival early in 1942, Spencer established comprehensive security systems and procedures, and he expected them to be applied and managed with rigour, precision, and consistency, which they were. Rank mattered, and army traditions prevailed, notwithstanding the organization's close liaison with the predominantly civilian Security Service in London. It is these few 'Ratcatchers of Tehran' – no more than 25 officers, ORs, and civilians – who are at the centre of this book (see Appendix A.1). When they first gathered in Tehran, few had any background in security intelligence, yet by the end of the war – a mere 28 months later – all had become highly professional operatives. Their astonishing success in protecting the security of an immense region in the face of German military threat and clandestine warfare, Persian fifth columnists and saboteurs, Soviet manoeuvres and postures, American disingenuousness and anglophobia, and the volatility of the pro-Nazi tribes undoubtedly merits this attempt to identify their achievements, construct their neglected narrative, and describe the historical context within which they functioned so effectively.

Notes

1. Eastward extension of the war in the Middle East, Report by the Joint Planning Staff, War Cabinet, 9 July 1941, CAB 79/12/41, The National Archives, Kew, Surrey (TNA).
2. The development of air control in Iraq, October 1922, AIR 19/109, TNA. See also David E. Omissi, *Air Power and Colonial Control: The Royal Air Force, 1919–1939* (New York: Manchester University Press, 1990), 20–1; Jafna Cox, 'A Splendid Training Ground: The Importance to the Royal Air Force of Its Role in Iraq, 1919–32', *Journal of Imperial and Commonwealth History* 13 (1985): 157–84. For a jaundiced view of the genesis of RAF aerial policing, interesting in that it examines the socio-cultural and intellectual rather than intelligence roots of air control in Iraq, see Priya Satia, 'The Defense of Inhumanity: Air Control and the British Idea of Arabia', *American Historical Review* 111, no. 1 (February 2006): 16–51; Satia's bibliographical footnotes are detailed and useful.
3. Satia, 'Defense of Inhumanity', 28.

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4. In October 1922. Ibid., 32.
5. *NSW*, 191.
6. Joyce Grenfell, *The Time of My Life: Entertaining the Troops, 1944–1945* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1989), 165.
7. Location and estimated strength of units in Iraq Command, AIR 23/5858, TNA.
8. Edwards to HQ RAF Middle East, Air Defence Iraq, 19 June 1943, AIR 23/5860, TNA.
9. An excellent recent biography of Wavell is Victoria Schofield, *Wavell: Soldier and Statesman* (London: John Murray, 2006). He was of course a general who later became a field marshal (and an earl); however, except for the occasional mention, especially when the first name is unknown, I have deliberately avoided the use of military ranks in this book, not out of disregard for such titles but because they changed like shifting sands during the war, and their use would become very muddled and confusing for the reader.
10. 'Brigadier Raymond John Maunsell', *The Peerage*, http://www.thepeerage.com/p45209.htm#i452081.
11. Maunsell to Head of MEIC, 6 June 1942, KV 4/306, TNA.
12. Memorandum on counter-intelligence in the Middle East area with special reference to Iraq and Persia, KV 4/223, TNA. The official narrative of SIME's establishment is to be found in F.H. Hinsley and C.A.G. Simkins, *British Intelligence in the Second World War*, vol. 4, *Security and Counter-Intelligence* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1984), 149–53.
13. Ibid., quoting MEIC telegram no. 5069, 4 October 1939. The brief history (1939–43) of the Middle East Intelligence Centre (MEIC), effectively superseded in mid-1943 by the Political Intelligence Centre Middle East (PICME), is described in H.O. Dovey, 'The Middle East Intelligence Centre', *Intelligence and National Security* 4, no. 4 (1989): 800–812. The security summaries provided by both organizations tended to concentrate on the Arab Middle East, to the exclusion of Persia, which was adequately covered by a separate series of summaries released by DSO Persia, now to be found in WO 208/1567–1569 and WO 208/3088-3089, TNA. Unfortunately, the first 15 summaries in the series, located in WO 208/3087, are listed as 'wanting' (i.e. although catalogued by TNA, they were never actually transferred to Kew from the War Office).
14. Memorandum on counter-intelligence in the Middle East area with special reference to Iraq and Persia, KV 4/223, TNA.
15. David Mure, *Practise to Deceive* (London: William Kimber, 1977), 49.
16. Diary of Guy Liddell, 22 October 1943, KV 4/192, TNA.
17. Mure, *Practise to Deceive*, 12. See also David Mure, *Master of Deception: Tangled Webs in London and the Middle East* (London: William Kimber, 1980), 15–16 passim.
18. Maunsell to Petrie, 18 September 1941, KV 4/306, TNA.
19. Memoir of work in the intelligence service in the Middle East, 1934–1943, Private papers of Brigadier R.J. Maunsell, 4829:80/30/1, Documents Collection, Imperial War Museum (IWM). I wish to thank the Trustees of the Imperial War Museum for allowing access to this collection held in the IWM Sound and Documents Section.
20. Ibid.

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21. Ibid.
22. Ibid.
23. The role and control of secret intelligence in support of both operations and security, Private papers of D.W.A. Mure, 2194:67/321/3, IWM. I wish to thank the Trustees of the Imperial War Museum for allowing access to this collection held in the IWM Sound and Documents Section.

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Index

Abadan, 1, 3, 15, 19, 40, 138, 166, 171, 225, 255
'Abbassian, Ghulam Reza', *see* Vaziri, Mohammad
Abshagen, Wolfgang, 176
Abwehr (Amt Ausland/Abwehr), 4, 31, 41–7, 51, 54, 59, 64, 66, 69–73, 75–6, 80–6, 88–9, 91–2, 96, 98–9, 108, 145–9, 162–4, 171, 173, 175–6, 178–80, 188, 245–6
Abwehr I (Active intelligence), 41, 43
  Abw I L (Air Force Intelligence), 41, 45, 66, 69, 84
  Abw I M (Naval Intelligence), 41, 43, 46, 66, 84–6, 88, 135, 163
Abwehr II (Sabotage/subversion), 41–3, 46–7, 59, 65–7, 69–70, 72–4, 77, 83–6, 89, 99, 139, 173, 176
  Abw II O (Orient), 66
  Abw II SO (Südost), 74
Abyssinia, 3
Achnacarry, 115
acquisition, 31, 58, 61, 104, 113, 116, 133, 144, 148, 155, 202, 207, 218, 223, 225
active espionage, *see* active intelligence
active intelligence, x, 27, 43, 80–1, 88–9, 109–13, 116, 155, 203, 225
aerial control, *see* air control
aerial policing, *see* air control
'A' Force, 4–5, 32–3, 92, 95–99, 136–7
Afghanistan, 44, 57, 198, 210
Africa, 235
Afruz, Nazifeh, 56
Aghevli, Farajollah, 52
Ahwaz, 15, 24, 132, 255
air control, 1
Air Officer Commanding (AOC), 3
air raids, Allied on Berlin, 73, 87, 92
Air Staff Intelligence Iraq (RAF), 1, 9
air substitution, 1
Akbari, Ahmed, 86, 89
Alborz (mountains), 108, 188
Aleppo, *see also* Centre d'Examination des Voyageurs (Anglo-French Travellers Examination Centre [CEV]), 20–1, 31, 71, 73, 81, 89, 149–50, 163,
Alexander, Harold, 98
Allen, Thomas ('Calvin Warne'), 204, 216–17, 250
Alov, Aleksandr, 177
America, American(s), *see* United States
American College (Tehran), 68
American University of Beirut (AUB), xiv, 206–7
Amt IV (RSHA Secret Police [Gestapo]), 92, 248
Amt VI (RSHA Foreign Intelligence), 40–2, 47, 57, 59, 65–7, 70–1, 74, 77, 81–2, 84, 87, 89, 99, 163, 165, 176, 178, 180, 189, 246
  Amt VI C 3, 87
  Amt VI C 14, 81–2
Amt Ausland/Abwehr, *see* Abwehr
Anglo-French Travellers Examination Centre, *see* Aleppo
Anglo-Iranian Oil Company (AIOC), 1, 15, 106–7, 233
Anglo-Soviet-Persian censorship administration, *see* censorship
Anglo-Soviet-Persian Treaty of Alliance, 18, 60
Anjuman-i-Tablighat-Iran, 52
Ankara, 57, 71
antisemitism, 22
Arabia, Arab(s), Arabic, 16, 110
Arak, *see* Sultanabad
Arbeitsgemeinschaft ehemaliger Abwehrangehöriger (AGEA), 179

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archives, ix–xii, xiv, 146, 170, 172, 174–5, 188–9, 217, 242–6, 249
American, ix, xii, 174, 182, 241, 246–7
British, ix, xii, 127, 147, 174, 182, 241, 244–8
German, ix, 174–5, 182, 241, 246
Russian, 174, 186–7, 248–9
Area Liaison Officer(s), x, 10–11, 15, 17–18, 29, 73, 106–7, 123, 133, 137–8, 255
Armenia, Armenian(s), 54, 56, 106, 123, 161, 180, 224
Armstrong, DeVere, 220–1
Aryan(s), Aryanism, 83, 91
Asaturov, Grigori, 56, 74, 156
Asia Institute (Tehran), 215
Assistant Defence Security Officer (ADSO), 15, 135, 153, 255
Ast Wien (Abwehr Vienna station), 72
Astor, Nancy, 2
Athenaeum (London club), 32
Attlee Directive, 113
Auslandsamt, 80, 88–9, 92, 246
Auslandsnachrichtendienst, *see* Amt VI
Australasia, ix
Australia, 2
Austria, Austrian(s), 19, 173, 217, 248
Auswärtiges Amt, 246
Axis, ix, 4, 11, 18–19, 21, 24, 26–7, 43–5, 51, 57, 64, 71, 83, 95, 97, 103, 132, 139, 171, 197, 218–19, 221, 225, 236, 241–2, 249
Ayrom, Muhammad-Husayn ('Jean de Monçay'), 86–8
Aznavour, Charles, 177
Azerbaijan, Azeri(s), 55–6, 82, 157, 223
Persian Azerbaijan, 88–9, 106, 165, 216

Baghdad, 9–10, 13–14, 16–17, 27, 29, 44, 71, 103, 121, 149, 158, 211–12, 232, 236, 244, 255
Baghdad Railway, 149
Baillon, Joseph, 45, 120–1
Baker, Colonel, 211
Bakhtiari (tribe), 40, 42–3, 54, 64–6, 82, 92, 106–7, 115, 122, 125, 160
Chahar Lang Bakhtiari (tribal branch), 122
Bakhtiari, Abdul Khasim Khan, 66
Baku, 43
Balkans, 84, 97–8
Baluchistan, 134, 171
Bandar Abbas, 44
Bandar-i-Shahpur, 160
Banquei, Grigore, 123
Baradaran Qashgai, *see* Qashgai Brothers
Barani, Ali, 128
Bari, xv
Barry, Edward, 220
Basra, 160
B Branch, *see* MI5
Bechtle, Richard, 69, 84
Beirut, 31, 102, 206–7
Belgium, Belgian(s,), 86
Berkaerstrasse (Amt VI HQ, Berlin-Schmargendorf), 189
Berlin, 33–4, 41–3, 46–7, 54, 57, 60, 64, 66, 68, 70–3, 80–1, 84–5, 88–9, 99, 114, 135, 139, 162–5, 173, 183, 185–6, 197, 200, 234, 246
Berlin Document Centre (BDC), 246
'Big Three' conference, *see* Tehran Conference
Bisitun, 24
'Black Eagle' movement, 89
blackmail, 145, 162
black market, 5, 86, 89, 223
Black Sea, ix
Bletchley Park, 96, 242
blind drop(s), 47
Blitzkrieg, 55
Blume, Günther, 65
Blunt, Anthony, 5
Bodansky, Forenc, 20
Boir Ahmedi (tribe), 42, 54, 64, 66, 106–7, 137
Bolshevik(s), Bolshevism, 61, 85, 158, 185
Boone, Philip, 202
Booth, Donald, 231

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Bose, Subhas Chandra, 70, 139
Bournemouth, 68
Brandenburgers (Lehrregiment Brandenburg zbV 800), 46, 246
Bristol Blenheim, 45
Britain, British, ix, xiv, 1–5, 9–11, 13, 14, 17–24, 26–7, 30, 32–4, 40–2, 45–6, 50–3, 55–6, 58–60, 65, 68–73, 75, 82–3, 87, 89, 91–2, 95, 97–9, 101, 104–12, 115–17, 121–2, 124–8, 133–5, 137, 139, 142, 144–6, 148–50, 153–60, 162, 164–6, 172–5, 177–80, 182–4, 186, 188, 195–203, 205–6, 211, 215–26, 231, 233–6, 238–48, 256
British Army, ix, 14, 97, 108
British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC), 256
British Library (St Pancras), 247
British Library Newspaper Collection (Colindale), 247
British Minister of State (Cairo), 11
British Overseas Aircraft Corporation (BOAC), 2
British Red Cross, 15
British Security Coordination (BSC), 113
British Troops in Egypt (BTE), 98
Bronze Star Medal (BSM), 207
Brown University, xiv
'Brylcreem Boys', 3
Budapest, xv, 198
Bulgaria, Bulgarian(s), 20, 56
Bullard, Reader, 1–2, 10–11, 13, 15–16, 23, 26, 34, 58, 90, 105–8, 111, 117, 120–1, 124, 133–4, 139, 153, 184–5, 196–202, 220, 239–40, 244–5, 247–8, 255
Bundesarchiv (Berlin-Lichterfelde), 246
Bundesarchiv-Militärarchiv (Freiburg), 246
Bundesnachrichtendienst (BND), 243
Burgess, Donald, 5
Bushire, 40, 133, 160

'C', *see* Menzies, Stewart
Caird, D.R., 15, 157, 236
Cairo, xv, 3, 11, 14, 29, 32, 73, 92, 95, 97, 102–3, 113, 115–16, 143, 149–50, 158, 172, 182, 186, 195, 204–6, 208–9, 211–13, 216, 220, 226, 231, 235–6, 247, 255
California, 68
Cambridge, 236, 247
'Cambridge Five', 6, 187
Camp 020, 87, 89, 142
Canada, xiv
Canaris, Wilhelm, 72, 173, 175–6, 188, 246
C&CS, *see* Government Code and Cipher School
card index, *see* registry
Caroe, Olaf, 139
Carstairs, Archibald 'Archie', 15, 236, 255
Casablanca, 173, 176
case files, 28–9, 232, 242, 255
Caspian Sea, ix, 25, 54, 90, 188
Caucasus, Caucasia, Caucasian(s), 12, 25, 52, 54, 59, 80, 83, 86, 106, 134–6, 221, 242
Cecil, William, 137
censorship, x, 17–21, 26, 105, 155–6, 160, 255–6
Central Asia, 1, 86
Central Intelligence Agency (CIA), xiv, 109, 112, 127–8, 215
Central United Council of Trade Unions (CUCTU), 159
Centre d'Examination des Voyageurs (Anglo-French Travellers Examination Centre [CEV]), 31, 73, 149–50
Channel Islands, 50
channels (operational, defined by Spencer), 39–47, 66, 81, 257
  Fifth-column Channel, 41, 43, 50–61, 75, 81, 257
  Quisling Channel, 41, 43, 46, 67–8, 80–92, 257
  Tribal Channel, 41, 43, 46, 64–77, 81, 257
Chile, 15
Churchill, Winston, xvi, 1–2, 107, 172–3, 177–8, 182, 185, 187, 200, 240, 245

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Churchill Archives Centre (Cambridge), 247
Church Missionary Society (CMS), 124
CICI, *see* Combined Intelligence Centre Iraq and Persia
CICI Baghdad, *see* Combined Intelligence Centre Iraq and Persia
CICI Charter, 16
CICI Tehran, *see* DSO Persia
cipher(s), *see* code, secret
Clark, Patrick, 189
Clarke, Dudley, 4, 33, 95–9, 137
Clausewitz, Carl von, 33
Clinton, William 'Bill', 247
code, Morse, 120, 164
code(s), secret, 42, 57, 96, 103, 158, 164, 242, 246
code name(s), *see* cryptonym(s)
Colditz, 150–1
Cold War, 6, 104, 113, 174, 226
College Park (Maryland), 246
Cologne, 69
Colonial Office (CO), 1, 30, 32, 125, 244, 256
Colvin, Ian, 173
Combined Chiefs of Staff, 221
Combined Intelligence Centre Iraq and Persia (CICI), x, 1, 9, 11–17, 22–3, 28–9, 44, 55, 58, 80, 96, 101–5, 116, 120–2, 126, 133–4, 138, 149, 155, 158, 166, 181, 183, 203–4, 206, 211, 216–18, 232–3, 244, 246–7, 255
Combined Services Detailed Interrogation Centre (CSDIC), Maadi, 73, 88, 143–9, 164, 225, 245
Commando Training Depot, 115
Committee of Five (*Mellium*), 52
communications, ix, 19, 23, 41–2, 44, 57, 75, 81, 96, 105, 139, 158, 204, 208, 211, 218, 242, 245
Companion of the Order of the British Empire (CBE), 235
Companion of the Order of St Michael and St George (CMG), 9, 235
concentration camp(s), 52
Connolly, Donald, 53, 196, 200–3, 210, 215, 220, 222, 226
consulate(s), *see* embassies/legations/consulates in Persia
Contemporary Arts Society, 234
'Cookridge, E.H.', *see* Spiro, Edward
Copenhagen, 198
Cornwell, David ('John Le Carré'), 30
Corps of Engineers, *see* US Army Corps of Engineers
Corps of Guides (IA), 9–10
counterespionage, xi, 19, 27, 30–1, 102, 110, 112–13, 156, 203, 218, 245
Counterespionage Branch (OSS), *see* X-2 Branch
counterintelligence, ix, 2–3, 9–10, 16, 26–8, 30, 32–4, 42, 47, 55, 66, 101–3, 105, 110–13, 116, 138, 156, 166, 183, 203, 208, 212, 218–20, 233–5, 240, 244–5, 249
Counter Intelligence Corps (CIC), x, 27–8, 152, 161, 188, 197, 203, 218, 220, 223–5, 247, 255
countersabotage, 107, 110, 115
countersubversion, 224, 235
courier(s), 18–20, 42, 55, 57–8
Crawford, Archie, 208, 216, 219
Crawford, J.F., 216
Crimea, Crimean, 82, 181
cryptonym(s), 27–8, 33, 45, 57, 82, 95, 120, 162–3, 171, 209, 212, 217–18
  BLACKGUARD, 163–4
  BUFFALO, 27
  BUNNY, 27, 217
  CHEESE, 95
  CUB, 214
  DRILLIG, 163
  ENIGMA, 96
  IBEX, 27
  KANGAROO, 216, 259
  KISS, 89, 157, 162–6, 243
  LION, 215
  MAJOR, 162
  MARQUIS, 164–6
  MAX, 10
  MORITZ, 10

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MUSA, 180
NIAZMAND, 122
SABA, 45, 162
TAPIR, 27, 214, 259
TEDDY BEAR, 27, 226, 259
TIGER, 27, 209, 214, 259
TIMBER WOLF, 27, 226, 259
TIMUR, 27, 215, 259
ULTRA, 96, 256
Czechoslovakia, Czech(s), 22, 71, 109, 255

D'Aeth, John, 123, 255
Daily Mail, 184
d'Alquen, Günther, xxvii–xxviii
Das Schwarze Korps, xxvii–xxviii
Darbyshire, Norman, 109, 111, 113, 127
Davis, Simon, 196, 241
Dawson-Shepherd, H.K., 16, 216
deception, strategic, *see* strategic deception
Defence Security Office(r) (DSO), x, 3, 5–6, 10, 16, 232
DSO Hong Kong, 234
DSO Persia (DSO) , x–xi, 6, 9–34, 40, 42, 44, 46–7, 50–61, 73–4, 82, 89, 101–5, 107–8, 111, 113, 116, 120–1, 127, 133, 135–9, 149, 151, 154–8, 160–2, 164–7, 170, 175, 179–82, 184, 188, 196, 201, 218, 220, 222–5, 232–4, 236, 240, 244, 255
DSO Syria, 150, 163
Delhi, 15, 116, 132–4, 136,
Delon, Alain, 177
'de Monçay, Jean', *see* Ayrom, Muhammad-Husayn
denazification, 69
Denmark, Dane(s), Danish, 22
Deputy Director of Military Intelligence (DDMI), 3
Deputy Director of Special Planning (DDSP), 115
Der Spiegel, 173
diaspora
German, in Persia, 19, 107, 246
Persian, in Germany, 80–92
Director of Special Planning (DSP), 115
Director of the Indian Intelligence Bureau (DIB), 134, 139
Distinguished Service Order (DSO), 16
distribution, 31, 105, 148, 183, 220, 255
Donovan, William 'Wild Bill', 113, 149, 173, 204, 218, 226
Dowlatshahi, Esmat, xv
Dorud, 122
double agent(s), double(s), doubling, 4, 21, 30, 55, 68, 95–6, 142, 156, 161–3, 166, 178–9, 218
double-cross, 157, 162, 243
Drake, R.G., 219
Dresden, 161, 198
Dreyfus, Grace, 197
Dreyfus, Louis, 127, 196–202, 210–11
DSO, *see* Defence Security Office(r)
DSO (Distinguished Service Order), 16
Dubois, Arthur 'Art', 27, 226, 259

Edinburgh, 30
Einsatzkommandos, 88
Eisenhower, Dwight 'Ike', 98, 182
El Alamein, ix, 2, 13, 44, 97, 105
Elizabeth I, 137
embassies/legations/consulates in Persia
British, x, xv, 1, 10, 19, 30, 106–11, 115–16, 124–8, 132, 135, 138–9, 153, 160, 184, 222, 240, 255
Japanese, 17, 43
Polish, 22
Soviet, 156, 160, 183, 185–6, 178
US, x, 182, 185, 198–9, 202, 204–5, 210–11, 215–16, 218, 222, 225
Emmaus (Imwas), 150–1
Erani, Tagi, 159
Erickson, John, 174–5
Erzerum, 51
escape(s), 24, 50, 72, 145, 150
espionage, active, *see* active intelligence
Ettel, Erwin, 200, 246
Euphrates (river), 2
evaluation, 61, 144, 208–9, 212, 218
Executive Committee (*ExKo*) (*Mellium*), 52–3
Political Subcommittee (*PoKo*), 52
Military Subcommittee (*MilKo*), 52

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Farago, Ladislas, 185, 199–200, 246
Far East, ix, 2, 17, 235
Farrashband, 45
Farsi (language), 84, 105, 110–11, 114–16, 134, 224
Farzad, Homayoun, 47
Fechner, Kurt, 176
Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), 225, 256
Federal'naya sluzhba bezopasnosti Rossiyskoy Federatsii, see FSB
Felmy, Hellmuth, 171
Feridun, 122, 125
Feruhar, Sadiq Khan, 122, 124–5, 127
Ferneinsatz (long-range operation), 148
field security officer(s), 24, 233
Field Security Section(s), ix, xi, 24–5, 29, 159, 233, 236
  72 FSS, 24–5
  73 FSS, 24–5, 233
  266 FSS, 24
  296 FSS, 24
  401 FSS, 24
  402 FSS, 24, 233
  403 FSS, 24
  408 FSS, 24
fifth column, fifth columnist(s), *see* channels
'Fifty-Year Rule', 247–8
filing, 255
Finland, 183
First Gulf War, 18
First World War, 1, 9, 135, 142, 171
Firuzabad, 45
Fleming, Ian, 177
FN Group, 52
Fond 500, 249
Foreign Office (FO), 30, 32, 101, 109, 124–5, 128, 132–4, 138, 203, 221, 244–5, 248, 256
Formations and units (Allied)
  2nd Indian Division, 98
  3rd Corps, 98
  5th Division, 97
  6th Soviet Armoured Division, 154
  6th Indian Division, 97–8
  6th Rajputana Rifles (IA), 15
  9th Army, 44, 98
  10th Army, 24, 33, 59, 97–9, 153, 160
  10th Indian Division, 108, 240
  10th Indian Motor Brigade, 97
  10th Queen Victoria's Own Frontier Force (IA), 10
  12th Army, 97
  12th Indian Division, 98, 255
  14th Corps, 97
  15th Armoured Division, 97
  15th Punjabis (IA), 10
  18th Indian Infantry Brigade, 10
  21st London Regiment (TA), 14–15
  22nd Indian Corps, 98
  25th Corps, 97
  31st Indian Armoured Division, 97–8
  50 Internment Camp, 150
  400th CIC Detachment, 220
  259th Military Police Company, 221
  727th Military Police Battalion, 221
  Casual Detachment 6614-SSS (CIC), 230
  Casual Detachment 6615-RRR (CIC), 230
  Corps of Guides (Cavalry) (IA), 9–10
  Dorset Regiment, 44
  First US Army Group (FUSAG), 97
  Force Kalpak, 44–5
  Green Howards, 114
  Hodson's Horse (IA), 15, 133
  Queen Victoria's Own Corps of Guides (Frontier Force) (Lumsden's) Cavalry (IA), 10
  Rifle Brigade, 16
  Royal Air Force (RAF), 1–4, 9, 13–14, 16, 45, 106
  Royal Army Medical Corps (RAMC), 144
  Royal Army Service Corps (RASC), 108
  Royal Artillery (RA), 9, 14–15, 108
  Royal Engineers (RE), 108, 135
  Royal Naval Volunteer Reserve (RNVR), 4
  Royal Navy (RN), 14, 240
  Royal Signals, 108
  Seaforth Highlanders, 120–1
  South Persia Rifles, 108
  Special Air Service (SAS), 44, 95, 114–16

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Special Boat Service (SBS), 44
Transjordan Frontier Force (TJFF), 3
US Army Corps of Engineers, xiv, 53, 203
Welch Regiment, 16
France, French, 15, 22, 69, 114–15, 149, 172, 174, 177, 183
Fraser, William 'Wak', 107–8, 125, 244, 255
Free Corps, *see* Freikorps Iran
Free French, *see* France
Free Persia movement, 85–8
Free Poles, Free Polish, *see* Poland, Pole(s), Polish
Freiburg University, xiv
Freikorps Iran (FKI), 70, 85–6, 171
Fremde Heere West (FHW), 98
Freshman, William, 177
Friston, 235
FSB, 174
fugitive(s), xi, 33, 45, 47, 50, 52, 59, 60, 124, 135
Führer, *see* Hitler, Adolf

Gailani, Rashid Ali, 53, 104, 171, 242,
Galadari, Abdullah, 44
Gamotha, Roman, 10, 40–1, 56, 67, 81–2, 85–90, 163, 165, 180, 189, 245–6, 257
Gasparian, Moses, 180
Gault, Charles, 126
Gehlen Organization, 69
Geneva, 68
Geneva Convention, 147
GENMISH, *see* US missions to Persia
Gentilomo, Giacomo, 177
Georgiades, Hans, 163
German Foreign Office, *see* Auslandsamt *and* Auswärtiges Amt
Germany, German(s), *see also* Nazi(s), xi, xiv, 4, 6, 9–12, 17, 19–20, 24–5, 29–30, 32–34, 39–47, 50–2, 54–6, 58–61, 64–75, 80–9, 91–2, 95–9, 101–6, 108, 110–12, 114, 116, 120, 122, 124–5, 132–9, 142–7, 149, 151, 155, 159, 161–4, 166–7, 170–88, 196–7, 199–204, 207, 217–19, 221, 226, 233–4, 238, 241–3, 245–9, 257
Gestapo, *see* Amt IV (RSHA Secret Police)
Ghir, 45
Gilan (province), 158
Gillies, J.A., 203
Glavnoye Razvedyvatel'noye Upravleniye, *see* GRU
Gleichschaltung (forcible assimilation), 55, 81
Glion, 68
Gloster Gladiator, 3
gold, 34, 58, 64, 74
Gorodetsky, Gabriel, 249
Government Code and Cipher School (GC&CS), 158, 256
Government of India (GOI), 132–4, 137, 139
Gräfe, Heinz, 57, 71–2
'Grant, Eliot', *see* Wilber, Donald
Gräwer, Walter, 171
Great Britain, *see* Britain
Great Game, 154–5, 195
Great Patriotic War, 186, 249
Great Powers, 195, 206
Great War, *see* First World War
Greece, Greek(s), 22, 27, 97–8, 110, 136, 149
Greely, John, 198, 201
Grenfell, Joyce, 2
Griffiths, Ian, 122–3, 125, 128
Griffiths, Leslie, 122–5, 128
GRU, 174
Gulmohammedi group, 51–2
Guterman, Captain (Soviet security), 156
G-2 (divisional intelligence), 115, 182, 202, 234

Habbaniya, 2–3
Haganah, 19
Hague, The, 87
Ham, *see* Camp 020
Hamadan, 15, 123, 255
Hamburger, Rudolf, 161–2
Hammill, C.F., 45
Hansen, Georg, 72, 75
Harriman, Averill, 182

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Harris/Griffiths murders, 122–9
Harris, R.C. Skipworth, 122–8
Harvard, 214, 218
Hashemite Kingdom (Iraq), 2
Havas, Laslo, 174–81, 187, 189
Hawker Hurricane, 2
Hayat, Ali, 52
Heliopolis, 143
Heydrich, Reinhard, 176
Hezb-i-Kabud, 52
Hezb-i-Nazi, *see* Gulmohammedi group
Hill, George, 200
'hillbillies' (Hill Project, Camp Ritchie, MD), 69
Himmler, Heinrich, 52, 87, 90, 176, 246
Hinsley, F.H. 'Harry', 246
historiography, xi–xiv, 179, 241, 250
Hitler, Adolf, 42, 50, 60, 64, 68, 70, 72, 76, 82, 87, 96, 111, 135, 173, 178, 180–2, 214, 242, 246
Hivedi (tribe), 122–3, 128
Hizb-i-Melliun, 41, 44, 52–61, 75, 81, 122
Hizb Mille Iran (HMI), 82–3, 85
Hochwalde, *see* Meseritz
Hoff, Hans, 27, 212, 217
Höhne, Heinz, 173
Home Office, 32
Hopkins, Harry, 185
Hormuz, 44–5
Hungary, Hungarian(s), xv, 19–20, 76–7, 108
Hurley, Patrick, 196
Hussein, Anvar, 58

Iceland, 197–8
Ilkhan (supreme chief), *see* Qashgai, Nasir Khan
illegal diamond buying (IDB), 234
Illinois State University, xiv
Imperial Bank of Iran, 123
Imperial War Museum (IWM), xv, 239, 247
India, Indian(s), ix, 1–3, 9–10, 15, 17, 24, 33, 44–5, 70, 97–8, 102, 104, 108, 113, 116, 121, 132–9, 171, 203, 238, 255
Indian Army (IA), ix, 1, 3, 9–10, 14–15, 97, 108, 132–3, 135, 157, 233
Indian Civil Service, 132
Indian External Affairs Department, 139
Indian Intelligence Bureau (IB), 15, 102, 134–5, 136, 139, 234, 244, 255
Indian National Army (INA), 70, 139
Indian Ocean, 132, 235
India Office, 132, 134
India Office Records (St Pancras), 247
Indian Political Intelligence (IPI), 134, 256
Indian Political Service, 132
infrastructure, *see also* oil, infrastructure, ix–x, 1, 40, 45, 61, 81, 90, 107, 188, 204, 208, 221, 242, 244
Intelligence Corps, *see also* Field Security Section(s), ix, xi, 24, 44
Intelligence Service Oliver Strachey (ISOS), 31
interpreter(s), 24, 47, 106, 160, 224
internee(s), internment, x, 17, 30, 41, 50, 55, 57, 59, 61, 89, 105, 121, 126, 128, 143, 145, 150–1, 156, 161, 181, 201, 246, 255
interrogation(s), x, 11, 21, 24, 29–30, 56–7, 61, 66, 71, 73, 87–9, 139, 142–51, 156, 161, 163–4, 171, 179, 225, 245, 255–6
Inter-Services Liaison Department (ISLD), *see also* MI6, xi, 5, 17, 95, 101–5, 108–11, 113, 116, 138, 150, 153, 155, 203, 206, 215, 255
invasion
  Anglo-Soviet, see also operations, plans, and initiatives, COUNTENANCE, 4, 9–10, 14, 41, 51, 70, 80, 82, 85, 105, 107, 115–16, 132–3, 154, 158, 171, 196, 200, 203, 240, 242
  Balkan, 98
  German, 13, 39, 41–2, 51–2, 59, 64, 83, 102, 105–6, 116, 204, 238, 241, 246

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Iran, Iranian(s), *see* Persia, Persian(s)
Iran-Azad, 52
Iran-Bidar, 52
Iranian Institute (New York), 204, 215
Iran-Parastan (IP), 85
Iraq, Iraqi(s), 1–3, 9–11, 17, 23–4, 27, 39–40, 53, 80, 97–8, 106, 112, 150, 160, 199, 204, 210–11, 215–18, 220, 235, 242, 244, 255
Iraq Command (RAF), 3
IRAQFORCE, 108
Irgun, 235
Isfahan, 15, 40, 42, 51–3, 58–9, 66, 115, 120–6, 132, 136, 163, 180, 188, 255
Israel, 151
Istanbul, 20, 56, 70–5, 163, 173, 249
Italy, Italian(s), 4, 20, 33, 43, 58, 84, 97, 177, 181, 219
Izmir, 89

Jackson, R., 73, 116, 137–8
Jakob, Konstantin 'Conny', 45, 59
Jamiatt-i-Melli, 52
Jangali (tribe), 54
Japan, Japanese, *see also* embassies/legations/consulates in Persia, 4, 17, 43–4, 52, 58, 85, 197
  submarines in the Gulf, 43–4
Jernegan, John 'Jack', 196, 199
Jew(s), Jewish, *see also* Zionist(s), 19–20, 76–7, 83, 196
Jewish Agency, 19
Jodl, Alfred, 72
Johnson, John 'Johnny', 106, 126
Joint Planning Staff, *see* War Cabinet
Jones, Kenyon, 16, 39
Jürgens, Curd, 177

Kabul, 57
Kalpak(s), *see* formations and units, Force Kalpak
Kaltenbrunner, Ernst, 87, 90
Karagoezlu (Persian officer and *V-Mann*), 88
Karlsbad (Karlovy Vary), 71
Kashani, Abol-Ghasem, 52–3
Kashefi, Ghulam, 58
Keitel, Wilhelm, 72, 173
Kellar, Alexander 'Alex', 6, 16, 23, 30–2, 56, 111–13, 149, 164, 234–6, 244, 255–6
Kensington, 15
Kerman, 132, 135–6
Kermanshah, 15, 51, 132, 255
Kern, Gary, 178, 181
Kerr, Philip, 178
Kertesz, Bela, 20
Kew (Surrey), 55, 178, 244, 246–7
KGB, 174, 178, 186, 188
Khalilnia, Firouz, 56, 58, 74
Khalilnia, Nadir, 56
Khan, Ibrahim, 134–5
Khan, Nasir, see Qashgai, Nasir Khan
Khorramshahr, 10, 132, 160, 223, 231
Khuzistan, ix, 1, 44, 107, 138, 223, 233
King's Regulations, 239
Kirpichenko, Vladimir, 186–7
Kirkuk, 3
KISS, *see* Salmassi, Mohamed
Kkonj, 45
Komitet Gosudarstvennoi Bezopasnosti, see KGB
Korel, Karl, 47
Kriegsorganisation Nahost (KONO) (Istanbul), 89
Kümel, Friedrich, 59
Kupal, Sadiq, 55
Kurdistan, Kurd(s), Kurdish, 40, 44, 54, 106, 108, 126, 172, 179, 205
  Iraqi, 2, 106
  Persian, 64, 106, 146, 216, 246
Kurmis, Martin, 66
Kursk, ix
Kuznets, Yuri, 186–7

Ladies' Home Journal, 215
Laghar, 45
Lagow (Łagów), 70
Lahousen, Erwin, 72, 76, 173, 176, 246
Lake District, 108
Lamb, Harold, 27–8, 215–17, 259
Lambton, Ann, xv, 109–11, 113, 127
landing ground(s), 45, 57
Langley (CIA HQ, Virginia), 129

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Latrun, *see* Emmaus (Imwas)
Lawrence, T. E. ('Lawrence of Arabia'), 114
Leary, Lewis, 208, 231
'Le Carré, John', *see* Cornwell, David
legation(s), *see* embassies/legations/consulates in Persia
Lehrregiment Brandenburg zbV 800, *see* Brandenburgers
Legion of Merit (LOM), 16, 220, 234
Leitstelle West (Mil D W), 69
Lenczowski, George, 91
Lend-Lease, ix–x, 27, 45, 53, 61, 65, 84, 159, 188, 197, 202, 218, 220–1, 224, 231, 247, 258
Leverkuehn, Paul, 33–4, 173
liaison, x, 6, 10, 15, 19, 22–3, 25–6, 30–2, 42, 66, 101–2, 108–9, 112–13, 117, 133, 135–6, 153–5, 159, 167, 173, 175, 218, 220, 233–4, 244, 256
Lichterfelde (Berlin), 246
Liddell, Guy, 4, 142, 165–6, 225
Liechtenstein, 86
lines of communication, 13, 25, 27, 40–1, 97, 203, 222
long-range aircraft, 2
long-range operation, *see Ferneinsatz*
London, 3, 6, 11, 14–15, 21, 23, 26, 29–32, 34, 41, 96–7, 103–4, 109, 116, 127, 132, 158, 187, 234, 236, 239, 244, 255
'lookups' (personality traces), *see* registry
Lorestan, 122, 125
Loretto School, 15
Loringhoven, Freytag von, 176
Lovell, Stanley, 172
'Lowe, Richard', *see* Upton, Joseph
Luftwaffe, 148, 176, 181
Lukin, Alexander, 181, 184, 187

Maadi, *see* Combined Services Detailed Interrogation Centre (CSDIC)
Macaulay, Thomas, 244
McCafferty, John, 220
Maclean, Fitzroy, 120–1, 126
Macmillan, Harold, 248
Magan, William 'Bill', 9, 15, 34, 102, 132–9, 234–5, 243, 255
Magdalen College (Oxford), 68
Mahru, 123
Majlis (Persian parliament), x, 18, 43, 51, 54, 57, 107, 159
Malaya, 134
Mand (river), 45
Marshall, George, 202
Marxist(s), 158–9, 161
Masjid-i-Suliman (Masjed Soleyman), 107
'Maston', 30
Mathieu, Mireille, 177
Maugham, Somerset, 177
Maunsell, Raymond, 3–5, 10, 15–16, 31–3, 58, 102–3, 113, 143–5, 149, 220, 235, 239, 255
MAX, *see* Mayr, Franz
Maximov, Mikhail, 156
Maxwell Fyfe Directive, 113
Mayr, Franz, 10, 16, 25, 29, 34, 40–4, 50–61, 65–7, 74–5, 80–1, 89, 122, 145–7, 150–1, 172, 179–81, 184, 220, 222–3, 245–8, 257
Mazanderan (province), 54, 163
Mediterranean, 96, 166
Medvedev, Dmitry, 187
MEF, *see* Middle East Forces
Mekran, 44
Melliun, *see Hizb-i-Melliun*
Member of the Order of the British Empire (MBE), 138, 234
Menzies, Stewart ('C'), 103
merger, SD-Abwehr, *see* unification,
'Merser, Ernst', 179–80
Meseritz (Międzyrzecz), 70, 86
Meshed, 132, 139
Mesopotamia, 1
Metropolitan Museum of Art, 204, 214
Middle East, xv, 1, 3–5, 10, 16–17, 20–2, 30–3, 39, 81, 95–9, 102–3, 111–16, 133–4, 137, 143, 150–1, 183, 195, 197, 199, 206, 208, 213–14, 218–20, 223–6, 235–6, 244, 246
Middle East Centre Archive (Oxford), 247

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Middle East Command (MEC), 98
Middle East Department, *see* Colonial Office
Middle East Forces (MEF), 4
Middle East Intelligence Centre (MEIC), 4, 244
Middle Temple, 30
Międzyrzecz, *see* Meseritz
MilAmt, *see* Militärisches Amt
military attaché, 10, 43, 106–7, 125, 211, 215
military intelligence, 25, 27, 203, 218, 223
Military Intelligence Museum and Archives (Chicksands), xv
Militärisches Amt (Amt Mil or MilAmt), 163, 176
  Mil C (Intelligence [East]), 69
  Mil D (Sabotage/subversion), 69
Millspaugh, Arthur, 18, 197–8, 202, 216, 259
Ministry of Economic Warfare (MEW), 256
Ministry of Supply (Delhi), 15
minorities, 54, 111, 207, 224
Mitford, Terence, 44
MI5 (Security Service), ix, 1–6, 9, 16, 23, 25, 29–32, 34, 56, 87, 95–6, 101, 103–4, 110–13, 116, 132, 139, 142–3, 158, 164–6, 183, 225, 232–6, 243, 245, 247–8, 255–6
  B Branch, 30, 234
    B1A, 234
    B1B, 31
    B4B, 31
  E Branch, 31
  F Branch, 31
MI6 (Secret Intelligence Service), *see also* Inter-Services Liaison Department, x–xi, 16–17, 30, 32, 70, 73, 95–6, 101–4, 109–13, 115–16, 127–8, 138, 153, 163, 166, 203, 215, 232, 243, 247, 256
mole(s)/plant(s), 41, 86, 144, 167, 176, 189
Molotov, Vyacheslav, 182, 184–5
Montreux, 68
morale, 23, 127, 144, 201, 208, 213, 224
moratorium, x, 27, 203
MORITZ, *see* Gamotha, Roman
Moscow, 26, 148–9, 156, 161, 164, 177, 182, 188, 235, 249
Moscow Centre, 56–7, 157–8, 164–5
Mossadeq, Mohammed, 128, 138, 215, 218
motivation, 138, 174, 188
Müller, Gottfried, 146–8
Müller, Heinrich, 248
Müller, Kunz, 74
Munich, 68
Mure, David, xv, 4–5, 32, 96, 239
Muslim(s), 82
Mussolini, Benito, 181

Naqvi, G.A., 139
Narodnyi Kommissariat Vnutrennikh Del (People's Commissariat for Internal Affairs), *see* NKVD
National Archives, The (Kew), 247
National Galleries of Scotland, 234
National Socialism, *see* Nazi
National Trust for Scotland, 234
National Union of Students (NUS), 31
Naubakht, Habibullah, 42–3, 52, 54
Naumov, Vladimir, 177
Naval and Military Club ('In & Out'), 32
Naval Officer in Charge (NOIC), 45
Nazi(s), ix–x, 6, 19, 31, 40, 43–5, 51–2, 55–6, 64, 68–9, 74–5, 80–3, 85, 87, 90–2, 104–5, 107, 114–16, 133, 135, 148, 154, 161, 171–8, 182–4, 187, 189, 196, 199–201, 207, 215, 223, 225, 236, 238, 241, 243, 245, 248
Near East, 87, 206, 208, 213
Near East College Association, 206
Near East Desk (OSS Washington), 206
Near East Section (OSS Cairo), 27, 195, 203, 206–10, 212–19, 259
Near Eastern Affairs Division (State Department), 205
neoimperialism, 195
New Delhi, *see* Delhi
New Julfa (Isfahan), 123

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New York, 196, 215
New York Times, 183
Nicolson, Harold, 114
Niedermayer, Oskar von ('Otto Normann'), 171
NKVD, ix, 25, 55–6, 111, 148–9, 153, 155–6, 158, 166–7, 172, 174, 178, 182, 186–8, 195, 249
'Normann, Otto', *see* Niedermayer, Oskar von
North Africa, 97, 197
Nuremberg Racial Laws, 91

Oberkommando der Wehrmacht (OKW), 69, 72, 173
Oberkommando des Heeres (OKH), 69
occupation, Anglo-Soviet, 11, 14, 25–6, 30, 41, 50, 54, 59, 64, 80, 82, 91, 104, 107, 110, 113, 117, 122, 126, 133, 139, 153, 157–9, 188, 196, 205, 214, 225, 235, 244, 249
Office of Strategic Services (OSS), x, 27–8, 112–13, 127, 148–9, 172–3, 179, 195, 202–220, 224–6, 231, 243, 247, 256, 259
Officer of the Order of the British Empire (OBE), 16–17, 233–5
oil, x, 1, 3, 30, 39, 40, 42, 127, 139, 155, 166, 195, 196, 201, 205, 225
  infrastructure, ix, 1, 40, 61, 107, 188, 208
  oilfield(s), ix, 40, 54, 57, 106–7, 138, 155, 159, 188
  refineries, ix, 1, 3, 19, 54, 155, 159, 208
operations, plans, and initiatives
  'AMINA' (unsubstantiated), 171, 174
  ANTON, 29, 33, 39, 47, 66, 71, 73, 81, 103, 107, 137–9, 146, 150–1
  'BAJADERE' (unsubstantiated), 171
  BARBAROSSA, 22, 154–5
  BOOT, 109, 127
  CASCADE, 33
  COUNTENANCE, ix, 10, 107, 133, 154, 240
  DORA, 16, 29, 39, 65–6, 89, 146, 172, 180–1, 185
  FRANZ, 16, 29, 33, 39, 47, 55, 65–6, 81, 146, 150–1, 172, 178, 180–1, 185, 220
  MAMMUT, 39, 146–7, 172, 246
  MINCEMEAT, 98
  NORMA, 81–2, 87, 90, 165, 189
  'LONG JUMP' ('WEITSPRUNG') (unsubstantiated), 170–89
  OVERLORD, 97
  PONGO, 120–9, 199
  QUICKSILVER, 97
  TPAJAX, 109, 127
Operations Division (CIC), 220
Operations Division (WD), 201
organization
  Abwehr, 145, 148, 179
  British intelligence/security, 3, 5–6, 9, 11–14, 17, 19, 28–30, 32, 39, 69, 95, 101, 103, 133–6, 143, 150, 158, 175, 216, 220, 224–5, 232, 255
  deception, 136–7
  German espionage/subversion, 4, 39, 41, 44, 46, 51–3, 55–6, 58–61, 103, 170, 184
  Jewish sabotage, 19
  SD, 145
  SOE, 105, 111, 113, 115–16, 125
  Soviet intelligence/security, 156, 166, 175
  US intelligence/security, 209, 213, 218–20, 224
Oshturan Kuh (mountains), 122, 124
Osobyi (special archive), 248
'Ossipov, Aleksandr', see Ovakimyan, Gaik,
O'Sullivan, Donal, 241
Ovakimyan, Gaik ('Aleksandr Ossipov'), 149
Oxford, 15, 68, 110–11, 127, 247

Pahlavi, Mohammad Reza Shah, 64, 68, 73, 75, 139, 165, 216
Pahlavi, Reza Shah, xv, 20, 23, 68, 86–7, 158–9, 240
Palermo, 198
Palestine, Palestinian(s), 19–20, 97, 116, 143, 150–1, 179, 181, 210, 235–6

Copyrighted material – 978–1–137– 55556–4

Copyrighted material – 978–1–137– 55556–4

Papen, Franz von, 74
parachute(s), parachuting, parachutist(s), 16, 47, 55, 60, 64–5, 81, 88, 107, 137, 139, 143, 150–1, 170–2, 179–80, 182, 185, 220, 245
Paris, 69–70, 86–7, 198
Pearl Harbor, 44, 197, 200
penetration, 56–8, 67, 106, 111–12, 134, 153, 164, 207, 215, 218–19, 222, 235
Penrose, Stephen 'Binks', 27, 113, 203, 206–8, 210–14, 216–18, 226, 247
Persia and Iraq Command (PAIC), 10, 12, 97–8
Persia and Iraq Force (PAIFORCE), x–xi, 12, 16, 24, 33, 45, 58, 61, 98–9, 104, 120–1, 134–5, 153, 175, 184, 221, 231, 233, 238, 240–1, 244
Persia (Iran), Persian(s), xi, xiv–xv, 1–4, 9–15, 17–34, 39–47, 50–2, 54–61, 64–75, 80–92, 96–9, 101–16, 120–8, 132–9, 143, 145–6, 149–51, 153–66, 170–2, 174–5, 177, 179–81, 185–9, 195–207, 210–12, 214–18, 220–6, 231–6, 238–47, 249–50, 255, 259
  agriculture, 198, 214
  armed forces/army, 45, 50–2, 54–5, 57–8, 65, 82, 88, 107, 122, 124, 127, 198, 201, 205
  art and architecture, 204, 214
  central, 132, 136, 224
  corruption, xi, 13, 18, 21, 23, 86, 105, 122, 239, 244
  east(ern), 18, 132–6
  economy, 13, 80, 91, 122, 126, 198, 206, 214–16, 244,
  gendarmerie, xi, 23–4, 26, 51, 60, 65, 198, 202, 205
  government, 13, 18, 20–1, 26, 40, 60, 64–5, 68, 71, 85, 106–7, 128, 160, 175, 197, 199, 214
    Department of Finance, 216
    Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 128
    Ministry of Industry, 85
  infrastructure, 40, 204, 221, 242
  industry, 20, 204
  Islamic Republic of, xi
  mineral wealth, 112, 235
  Nazi infiltration of, ix, 17, 29, 32, 34, 39–40, 43, 47, 50–1, 66, 143, 200
  north(ern), 18, 20–1, 24, 26, 41–2, 51, 55, 74, 88, 90, 108, 110–11, 113, 171, 178, 188, 196, 205, 226
  northeast(ern), 214
  northwest(ern), 51, 106, 216
  oil, 39, 155
  public health, 198
  police, xi, 11, 18, 21, 23–4, 26, 29, 51, 55, 60, 198, 205
  polity, ix, 26, 61, 80, 122, 159, 204, 223, 238, 242, 264
  south(ern), 18, 41, 44–5, 51, 64, 66, 74, 110–11, 114–15, 120, 134–6, 160, 171, 177, 224
  southeast(ern), 132, 135
  south(western), 3, 40, 42, 46, 66, 92, 139, 159
  tribe(s), xi, 6, 13, 25, 40–3, 45–6, 54, 57–8, 64–8, 70–1, 73–5, 81–2, 84, 106–7, 116, 122–5, 128, 132–3, 137, 139, 159–61, 178, 218–19, 223, 225, 244, 257
  west(ern), 40, 64, 216, 219
Persia Section (formerly DSO Persia), 232–3
Persian Azerbaijan, *see* Azerbaijan
Persian Baluchistan, *see* Baluchistan
Persian Free Corps, see Freikorps Iran (FKI)
Persian Kurdistan, *see* Kurdistan
Persian Gulf, ix–x, 25, 27, 39, 43–5, 84, 112, 159–60, 163, 196, 203, 221
Persian Gulf Service Command/ Persian Gulf Command (PGSC/ PGC), 27, 113, 153, 161, 200, 202–3, 210, 215, 218, 220–3, 226, 231, 233, 247, 258–9
Persian Nationalist Society, 74
Persianist(s), 109, 127, 215, 218, 236

Copyrighted material – 978–1–137– 55556–4

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personality, personalities, 15, 28, 42, 52, 54–5, 83, 115, 129, 137, 148, 150, 156, 164, 177, 189, 210, 215, 217, 236, 250, 255
personality traces, *see* registry
Petrie, David, 104
Pilditch, Denys, 134, 139
pilfering, x, 221
Poland, Pole(s), Polish, xi, 22, 70, 83, 91, 97–8, 109, 239, 255
Polesello, Giovanni, 20
political intelligence (POLINT), ix, 80, 133, 223–4, 255
Political Warfare Executive (PWE), xv, 114–16
port(s), ix, 24–5, 40, 57, 90, 159–60, 202, 208, 221, 231, 256, 258
positive vetting, x, 5, 19, 21, 223, 255
postoccupation(al), 43, 51–2, 90, 104–7, 160, 166, 173, 225, 233
Pownall, Henry, 12, 16, 39–40, 42, 241
Preventive Intelligence Arab World (PIAW), 3
Princeton, 215, 218
prisoner(s), POW(s), 22, 24, 142–151, 180, 256
propaganda, 17, 26–7, 43, 51–2, 54, 83–4, 90, 105–7, 109–110, 114–16, 158–9, 165, 170, 172, 174–8, 181, 183, 185–6, 197, 203, 239, 246–7
Putin, Vladimir, 188
Putz, Gerhard, 46, 66–7, 69–72, 74–7, 83–4, 86, 89, 257

Qashgai (tribe), 40–5, 54, 64–75, 81–4, 92, 106–7, 132, 137–8, 160, 177–8, 180, 257
Qashgai Brothers (*Baradaran Qashgai*) (see also Qashgai, Malek Mansour and Qashgai, Mohamed Huseyin), 46, 66, 68–75, 81–3, 85, 87, 91–2, 180, 257
Qashgai, Bibi Khanum, 68, 73, 137–8
Qashgai, Khosrow Khan, xi, 67–9
Qashgai, Malek Mansour (MMQ), 46, 67–9, 72–3, 83
Qashgai, Mohamed Huseyin (MHQ), 46, 67–9, 70, 72–4, 83, 86
Qashgai, Nasir Khan, xi, 43–6, 65, 67–8, 71, 73, 137–8
Quetta, 9, 134, 136
Quinan, Edward, 108
quislings, 41, 43, 46, 64, 66–8, 80–92, 257
Qum, 11, 15, 187
Quraishi, Hassan, 82–3, 180

radio, *see also* wireless telegraphy (W/T), 33, 47, 90, 144, 183–4, 186, 247
Radio Berlin, 245
Radl, Karl, 189
railway, *see* Trans-Iranian Railway
Railway Section (*Melliun*), 52–3
'ratcatchers', 6, 9–34, 56, 153, 234, 244
Reading, 68
realignment, 90, 104, 160, 219, 225
records, *see* registry
recruitment, 10, 15, 19, 23, 29, 31, 55–7, 74, 80, 85–6, 88, 90–1, 108–9, 134–6, 155–7, 159–61, 206, 208, 213–16, 224, 226
Red Army, ix, 43, 85, 154, 156, 159–60, 249
Red Navy, 160
Reichsführer-SS, *see* Himmler, Heinrich
Reichssicherheitshauptamt (RSHA), 41, 81–2, 86–8, 90, 165, 249
  see also Amt IV, Amt VI
Reichsstelle für den Aussenhandel (RfA), 91
refineries, *see* oil, refineries
registry, x, 19, 61, 28, 208, 232, 247, 249
Reichsführer-SS, *see* Himmler, Heinrich
Reilly, Mike, 182
Research and Development Branch (OSS), 172
Resht, 111, 132
resistance
  Belgian, 86
  French, 114–15
  German, 72

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Reykjavik, 196, 200
Reza Shah Pahlavi, *see* Pahlavi, Reza Shah
Rezun, Miron, 175
RIA Novisti, xiv
Ridley, Clarence, 198, 201
Rigg, Robert, 211
Roberts, Douglas, 16
Robertson, T.A.R. 'Tar', 31, 96, 102
Rockstroh, Werner, 180, 245
Rodd, Gustav, 143
Roger, Alan, 14–15, 29–30, 32, 34, 55–6, 113, 116, 135, 138, 153, 155–6, 161–2, 164–7, 232, 234, 243–4, 255
Romania, Romanian(s), 20
Ronson Ltd, 16
Roosevelt, Franklin (FDR), 173, 177–8, 182–5, 187, 200
Rowanduz, 2
Royal Horticultural Society, 234
RSHA, *see* Reichssicherheitshauptamt
Russia, Russian(s), x–xi, 4, 6, 10–12, 14–15, 17–19, 20–2, 25–7, 33, 39–41, 43–44, 50–1, 53–8, 60–1, 67, 69, 72, 74, 76, 81–4, 86–90, 97, 99, 104–16, 122, 124, 132–4, 136, 139, 148–9, 153–67, 170–89, 195–7, 200–3, 205–7, 214–19, 221, 224–6, 233, 235, 238–42, 247–9, 255
Russian State Military Archive (Moscow), 249

SABA, *see* Schulze-Holthus, Julius Berthold
sabotage, saboteur(s), ix–x, 6, 19, 26–7, 33, 40, 42–7, 52–3, 57, 59–60, 66, 71, 81–2, 84, 91, 99, 105–7, 110, 115–16, 121, 145, 148, 172, 189, 203, 207, 218, 221–3, 238, 244
Salmassi, Mohamed, *see also* cryptonym(s), KISS, 89, 157, 162–6, 243
Sanjari, Lili, 54, 60
Santa Barbara, 198
Sante Fe Railway, 203
Sargent, Joseph, 177
Saturday Evening Post, 215
Saudi Arabia(n), 196, 205, 210
Schellenberg, Walter, 82, 87–8, 90, 99, 176, 178–9, 181–2, 188–9
Schenker & Co, 40
School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS), 109
Schuback, Kurt, 70–1, 165, 180
Schüler, Werner, 43, 46, 67–8, 84–5, 87–9, 163
'Schultz, Walter', *see* 'Svetlov, Ilya'
Schulze-Holthus, Gertrud, 176
Schulze-Holthus, Julius Berthold, 29, 33–4, 41–3, 45, 51, 54, 58–9, 65–6, 69, 73, 80–1, 84, 137, 139, 150–1, 162, 170, 176–81, 245, 257
Schutzstaffel (SS), 40–1, 45–6, 60, 64, 70–2, 75, 83, 89–90, 179, 189, 200, 246
  Security Service (SD), see Amt IV, Amt VI
  Waffen-SS, 88, 181
Schwarzkopf, Norman, 18, 23, 198, 202
Scott, D., 115
Scottish Tourist Board, 235
SD, *see* Amt III, Amt IV, Amt VI
second front, 22
Second World War, xi, xii, 1, 28, 64, 85, 104, 113, 132, 142, 173–4, 197, 206, 236, 240–3, 245, 247, 249
secret code, *see* code, secret
Secret Intelligence Service, *see* MI6
security intelligence, x, 3–4, 6, 13, 15–16, 27–8, 31–3, 41, 46–7, 58, 95, 101, 105, 116, 120, 133–5, 139, 155, 166, 171–2, 175, 203, 212, 225, 233, 235, 241, 243–5
Security Intelligence Far East (SIFE), 235
Security Intelligence Middle East (SIME), ix, 3–6, 9–10, 14, 16, 25, 31–2, 56, 58, 73, 95–6, 102, 105, 112–13, 116, 120, 143, 145, 149–51, 158, 163–4, 170, 184, 206, 220, 224–5, 234–5, 239, 244–6, 255
Security Service, *see* MI5
Seekriegsleitung (SKL), 181

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Seistan, 132
Senior Naval Officer Persian Gulf (SNOPG), 45, 160
Sennandaj, 15, 255
Seth, Ronald, 184
Seubert, Franz, 181
shah, *see* Pahlavi, Reza Shah and Pahlavi, Mohammad Reza Shah
Shahrukh, Shahbahram, 82–5, 87–9
Shearman, S.D., 162
Shelton, Francis, xv–xvi, 108–9
Shiraz, 15, 40, 51, 58, 73, 116, 132, 137–8, 188, 255
Siahpushan, 52
Siberia, 43, 239
Sicherheitsdienst (SD), *see* Amt IV, Amt VI
signals intelligence (SIGINT), 29, 42, 97, 158, 246
SIME, *see* Security Intelligence Middle East
Simon Fraser University (SFU), xiv
Singapore, 235
Skorzeny, Otto, 177–8, 181–2, 187, 189
Skrine, Clarmont, 240
Slim, William 'Bill', 108, 240
Sluzhba vneshney razvedki, *see* SVR
small sabotage, x
Smert' Shpionam, *see* SMERSH
SMERSH, 249
Smith, Arthur, 231
smuggler(s), smuggling, 55, 58, 86–7
social class, 147
SOE, *see* Special Operations Executive
Sonderstab F, *see* Felmy, Hellmuth
Sosnin, Major (Soviet security), 156, 164–5, 167
Soviet(s), *see* Russia, Russian(s)
Soviet Army, *see* Red Army
Soviet Russia, *see* Russia
Soviet Union, *see* Russia
Soviet zone, ix–x, 51, 54–5, 88, 110–11, 139, 154, 155, 159, 165–6, 217
special forces, 46, 148, 171, 182, 246
Special Operations Executive (SOE), ix, xv, 15, 44, 86, 101, 104–11, 113–17, 120–2, 124–7, 138, 149–50, 153, 206, 239, 256
special source exploitation (SSE), 256
Spencer, E. L. 'Joe', x, 6, 9–11, 14–16, 18, 22–5, 27–30, 32, 34, 40–3, 46–7, 51–2, 54–7, 59–61, 66, 68, 74–5, 81–3, 91, 101–4, 108, 110–13, 116–17, 125, 137–8, 149–50, 153–9, 161, 164, 166–7, 172, 175, 183–6, 196, 217, 225, 233–4, 243–4, 255
Spiro, Edward ('E.H. Cookridge'), 184–5
SS, *see* Schutzstaffel
Staisch, Theodor, 180
Stalin, Josef, 75, 104, 106, 148, 157, 165–6, 173, 177–8, 182, 187, 200, 205
Stalingrad, ix, 2, 13, 59, 71, 80, 82, 86, 90, 105, 136, 154
Stalinism, Stalinist(s), ix–x, 74, 156, 158–9, 178, 181–2, 188–9
St Andrew's, 44
St Antony's College (Oxford), xv
State Department, *see* US Department of State
Stauffenberg, Claus von, 72
staybehind agents, staybehinds, 41, 88, 102, 134, 136–7, 176, 234, 245
Stellenbosch University, xiv
Stephenson, William, 113
Stock Montage, xiv
Stoker, Linda, 172
strategic deception, 33, 95–9, 136
Strong, Kenneth, 182–3, 185
student(s), 30–1, 80, 83, 86, 91, 235
Stuttgart, 148
subversion, subversive(s), x, 17, 26–7, 40–2, 44, 46, 51, 53–4, 57–9, 65, 81, 88, 90, 99, 107, 109, 116, 121–2, 126–7, 134, 145, 151, 156, 167, 203, 207, 219, 224, 234–5, 238, 244, 246
Suez, 2, 112, 242, 245, 249
Sultanabad (Arak), x, 11, 55, 57, 145, 150, 255
Sultanzadeh, Moussa, 74
summaries, x, 34, 41, 66, 73, 81, 120, 156, 170, 183–4, 235, 244, 255

Copyrighted material – 978–1–137– 55556–4

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Sunday Times, 181–2
surveillance, x, 25, 32, 40–1, 59–60, 75, 87, 161, 164, 218
'Svetlov, Ilya', 176
'Svetlov, Anna', 176
SVR, 174
Sweden, 198
Sweerts, Pierre, 86–7
Switzerland, Swiss, 56, 74, 86, 110, 161, 177, 179
Sykes, Christopher, 105, 114–16, 239
Sykes, Edward, 114–15
Sykes, Egerton, 109, 111
Sykes, Mrs K.E., 109
Syria, Syrian(s), 21, 74, 97, 150, 163, 210, 255

Tabriz, 51, 111, 154, 158, 166, 216
Tarbiat, Ardishir, 83
TASS (Soviet news agency), 109
Tatars, 82
Taurus (mountains), 44
Tehran, x, 1, 6, 9–11, 14–19, 22, 24–5, 27–8, 30, 32, 34, 40–3, 47, 51, 53–9, 61, 65–8, 73, 75, 81, 83–6, 88–9, 91, 99, 102–4, 106–9, 115–17, 122, 127–8, 132–3, 135–7, 139, 146, 149, 153, 156–61, 163–7, 172, 174–89, 196–7, 199–202, 204–5, 210–11, 214–16, 218, 220, 222, 224, 232, 234, 236, 239, 243–4, 255
Tehran Conference, 24, 34, 170–89, 197, 200, 220
Tehran Military School, 85
Territorial Army (TA), 14, 114
Thirty Committees, *see* XXX (Thirty) Committees
'Thirty-Year Rule', 247–8
Thistlethwaite, Richard 'Dick', 34, 56, 74, 166, 183, 234–5, 255
Thompson, Walter 'Tommy', 172
Thornhill, Cudbert, 114–15
Tirpitzufer (Abwehr HQ, Berlin), 72
Tito, Josip Broz, 120
Tobin, Edward, 220
Tokyo, 44
Toronto, 236
tradecraft, 25, 54, 136
training, *see also* W/T training, 3, 15, 34, 40, 44, 47, 54–5, 70, 85–6, 97–8, 106, 115, 120, 136, 143, 148, 159, 162, 164, 171, 208, 213, 216–17, 222, 226, 243, 245
Transcaucasia, ix, 25, 33, 42, 97, 134, 202, 241, 246
Trans-Iranian Railway (TIR), ix–x, 24, 40, 42–3, 47, 53, 65, 67, 84, 106–7, 159, 203, 221–2, 255
travel control, x, 17, 20–1, 156, 256
Trevelyan, George, 244
Trial of the 53, 159
TRIANGLE (name for ULTRA in the Middle East), *see* cryptonym(s), ULTRA
tribe(s), tribal, *see* Persia (Iran), Persian(s), tribes
Trinity College (Oxford), 15
Tripartite Censorship Commission, *see* censorship
Tudeh Party, x, 107, 158–9, 218
Turkey, Turk(s), Turkish, xv, 3, 18–21, 27, 42, 44, 50–1, 55–8, 67–8, 70–2, 74–5, 84, 88–9, 91–2, 95, 102, 106, 149–51, 161, 163, 166, 171, 181, 202, 223
Turkhud, David, xv, 108–9
Turki (language), 64
Twenty Committee, *see* XX (Twenty) Committee
typhoid, typhus, 47
T-26 (tank), 154

Ukraine, Ukrainian(s), 161
Underwood, Herbert, xv, 10, 106–9, 115–16, 125, 244
United Kingdom, x, 143
United Kingdom Control Commission (UKCC), 199
United States (US), America, American(s), xiv, 6, 10, 13, 16, 18–19, 23, 26–8, 40, 53, 56, 60, 69, 83, 112–13, 116, 127–8, 136, 149, 153–4, 159–61, 172, 174–5, 177–8, 182, 184–6, 188, 195–7, 199–207, 209, 213–14, 216–17, 219–26, 231, 234, 236, 238–9, 241, 243, 246–8

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United States Holocaust Memorial Museum (USHMM), xiv
University of South Africa (UNISA), xiv
University of Waterloo, xiv
Upton, Joseph ('Richard Lowe'), 27, 204, 209, 214–16, 259
US Army Forces in the Middle East (USAFIME), 226
US Army Office of Technical Information (OTI), 215
US Department of State, 127, 196, 198–9, 201, 205, 208, 210–12, 219,
US Department of War, 201–2, 221
US Military Mission to Moscow, 148
US missions to Persia
  Greely/Ridley mission (armed forces), 195, 198, 201
  Millspaugh mission (economy), 18, 195, 197–8, 202, 216, 259
  Schwarzkopf mission (GENMISH) (gendarmerie), 18, 23, 198, 202
  Sheridan mission (food and supplies), 195, 198
  Timmerman mission (police), 195, 198
  Wheeler mission (Lend-Lease), 197, 203
US National Archives (College Park), 246
USS General W. P. Richardson (troopship), 231
US Steel, 195

Vartanyan, Gevork, 185–8
Vartanyan, Goar, 185–6
Vaziri, Hissam, 55, 56
Vaziri, Mohammad ('Ghulam Reza Abbassian'), 42, 51, 53–7, 59, 67, 74–5, 157, 161–2
Vienna, 56, 72, 75, 180
visa control, x, 11, 17–18, 20–2, 91, 161, 255
Vlasov, Andrej, 178–9
Vyshinski, Andrej, 182

Waffen-SS, *see* Schutzstaffel
Wagner, Hans-Otto ('Dr Wendel'), 69–71, 83–4
Wahabzadeh, Parvis, 70–1, 91–2
Waldegrave Initiative, 247
Walla Walla (Washington State), 247
War Department, *see* US Department of War
'Warne, Calvin', *see* Allen, Thomas
War Office (WO), 14, 16, 243, 248
Washington, DC, 127, 129, 149, 195–7, 201–2, 204–7, 209, 212, 214–15, 220, 226, 231, 235
Wassmuss, Wilhelm, 114
Waterman, Denis, 177–8
Watson, Captain, 232
Waugh, Evelyn, 114–15
Wavell, Archibald 'Archie', 3, 11, 95–6, 137
W Board, 242
Weinberg, Gerhard, xv, 91, 241
Wehrmacht (German Armed Forces), 64, 69, 72, 80, 86, 88, 133
Welles, Sumner, 201
Wemyss, Colville, 202
Wende (turning point), ix, 64
Wester Ross, 234
Western Desert, 58, 70
Wheeler, Raymond, 197, 203
White, Dick, 31, 143, 234
Whitehall, 107, 133, 235, 245
White Russian, 15, 157, 178
White's (club), 32
Whitman College (Walla Walla), 247
Whittall, Arthur, 70–1, 73
Wickens, George, 15, 24, 232, 236
Wilber, Donald ('Eliot Grant'), 27, 127, 204, 209, 214–16, 218, 259
Wilson, Henry Maitland 'Jumbo', xv, 10–13, 16, 58, 98, 120, 221, 240–1
Wilson, Patrick Maitland, 16, 241
wireless telegraphy (W/T), 31, 34, 42–3, 57, 106, 120, 139, 148, 162–4
Wood, E.K. 'Chokra', 9–10, 13, 16–17, 44, 58, 103–4, 113, 149, 203–4, 211, 216, 233, 255
Wright, Edwin 'Ed', 27, 226, 259
Wright, Peter, 110–11
W/T, see wireless telegraphy

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W/T training, 148, 164
Wüstensonderverband 287 (287th Special Desert Unit), *see* Felmy, Hellmuth

XX (Twenty) Committee, 96, 242
XXX (Thirty) Committees, 96
X-2 Branch (OSS counterintelligence), 202, 208, 212, 218–20

Yegorov, Victor, 181, 187
Yezd, 136
Young, T. Cuyler ('Roger Black'), 217–18
Yugoslavia, Yugoslav(s), 22, 120

Zagros (mountains), 64, 122
Zaehner, Robin, 107, 109–13, 117, 127, 138, 155, 215, 255
Zahedi, Fazlollah, xi, 52, 59, 109, 120–2, 124–8, 137, 151, 199
Zahidan, 136
Zahrai, Sayyid Murad, 123, 128
Zamani, Haidar, 128
Zanouzi, Bahlul, 56, 58
Zazb, 123
Zemskov, Nicolai, 156
Zentrum für Militärgeschichte und Sozialwissenschaften der Bundeswehr (ZMSBw), xiv
Zionism, Zionist(s), 19, 235–6

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